

Ayo Dosunmu and the Value of Playoff Stability

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Introduction

Ayo Dosunmu has been one of the more interesting bench pieces in the NBA over the last half decade. Even on a middling Bulls roster where young talent often seemed to stall out, his efficiency stood out.

At the deadline, Chicago moved on from its hometown guard. For Dosunmu, the move to Minnesota was an opening. For the Wolves, it was a bet on a guard who could fit around stars while still handling real on-ball responsibility in smaller doses.

That bet has more than paid off.

Dosunmu took an already efficient offensive profile and added another layer Minnesota’s offense needed: rim pressure, shooting, and enough on-ball creation to take some of the burden off Julius Randle and Anthony Edwards.

Now, with the Wolves up 3-2 despite losing both Edwards and Donte DiVincenzo, that skill set has become central to the series. Denver has made a habit of surviving deficits, and Minnesota cannot afford to let this turn into another one of those comebacks. If Minnesota is going to close this out, Dosunmu has to keep giving them enough creation to avoid offensive droughts.

Deadline Context

Table 1: Ayo Dosunmu pre-trade vs post-trade production

Split	Team	GP	MPG	PTS	REB	AST	STL	TOV	FG%	3P%	FT%	FTA
Pre-Trade	Chicago	24	28.9	14.4	4.2	3.5	1.0	1.5	52.1%	41.4%	92.5%	1.7
Post-Trade	Minnesota	45	26.4	15.0	3.0	3.6	0.8	1.4	51.4%	45.1%	85.7%	2.3

The post-deadline box score did not scream transformation, but it showed why the fit made sense. In Minnesota, Dosunmu added a little more free throw pressure, shot the ball better from three, kept his assist production steady, and fouled less despite playing real rotation minutes.

That kind of margin improvement is crucial for a team already built around stars, and his role has only grown in the playoffs.

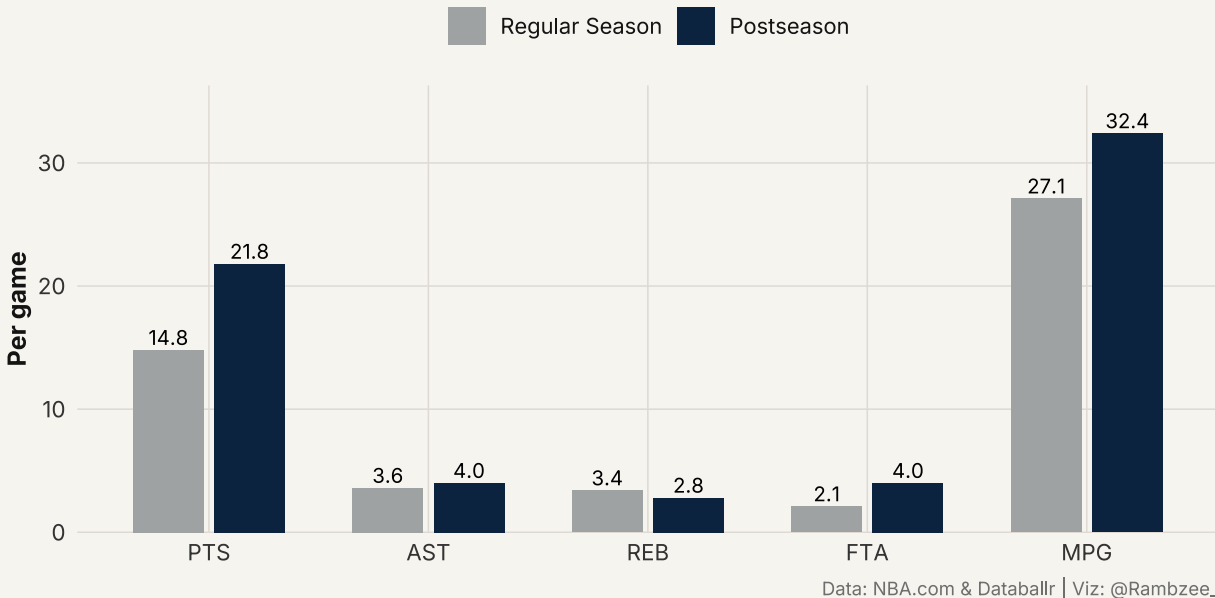
Ayo’s Playoff Arrival

Table 2: Season baseline vs current playoff series

Split	GP	PTS	AST	REB	TS%	2P%	3P%	FT%	FTA	TOV	MPG	+/-	FG2A	FG3A	FT
Regular Season	69	14.8	3.6	3.4	63.0%	56.3%	43.9%	87.6%	2.1	1.4	27.1	-0.9	6.8	4.1	19.1
Postseason	5	21.8	4.0	2.8	74.9%	64.3%	54.5%	95.0%	4.0	1.4	32.4	-1.4	8.4	4.4	31.1

Ayo's role has expanded without more mistakes

Regular season baseline vs first five playoff games

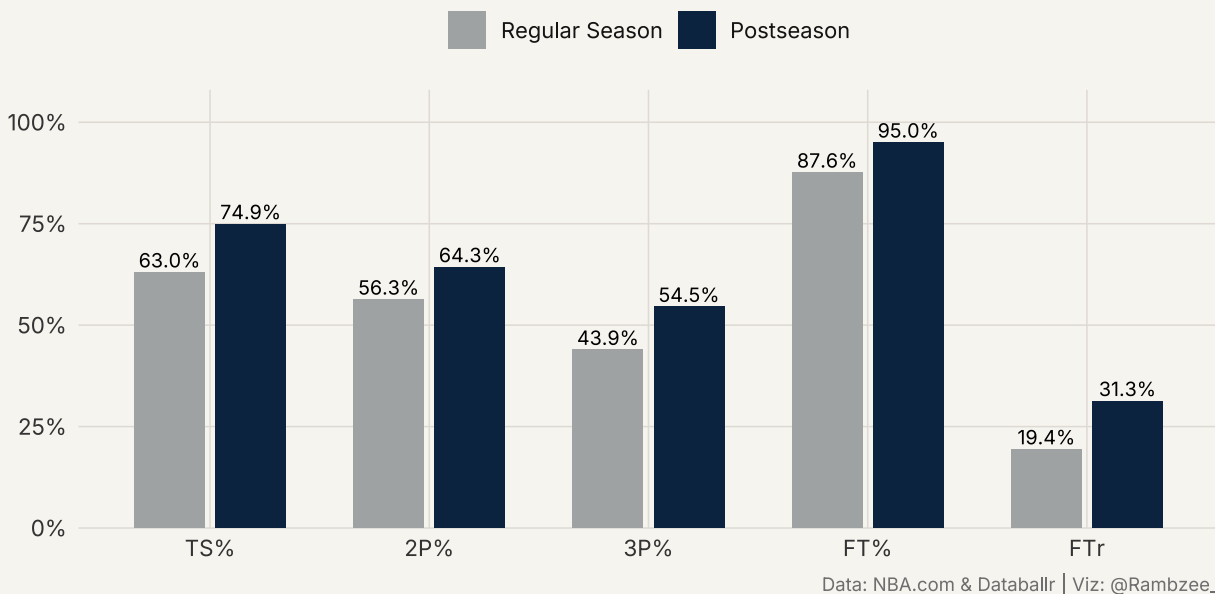


The bump is not just points. His minutes are up, his shot volume is up, and his free throws have nearly doubled. Dosunmu has taken advantage of a disappointing Denver defense and punished the gaps they have given him.

The more interesting part is that the added responsibility has not come with a turnover spike. More on-ball work usually brings more mistakes, but Dosunmu has stayed at **1.4 turnovers per game**, the same as his regular-season baseline, while taking on a bit more creation.

The scoring jump has held efficiency

More usage, no clear drop in shot quality



Ayo was already one of the most efficient guards in basketball during the regular season, sitting around +5 rTS.

The playoffs have pushed that even further. He is at a staggering 75% TS, which is not sustainable, but it is not built only on three-point variance either.

The more important shift is how often he is getting downhill. Dosunmu has used his quickness to create advantages earlier in possessions, which has opened cleaner looks for both himself and his teammates. That added pressure has shown up in the numbers too, with his free throw rate and true shooting both jumping by nearly 10 percentage points.

Shot Profile

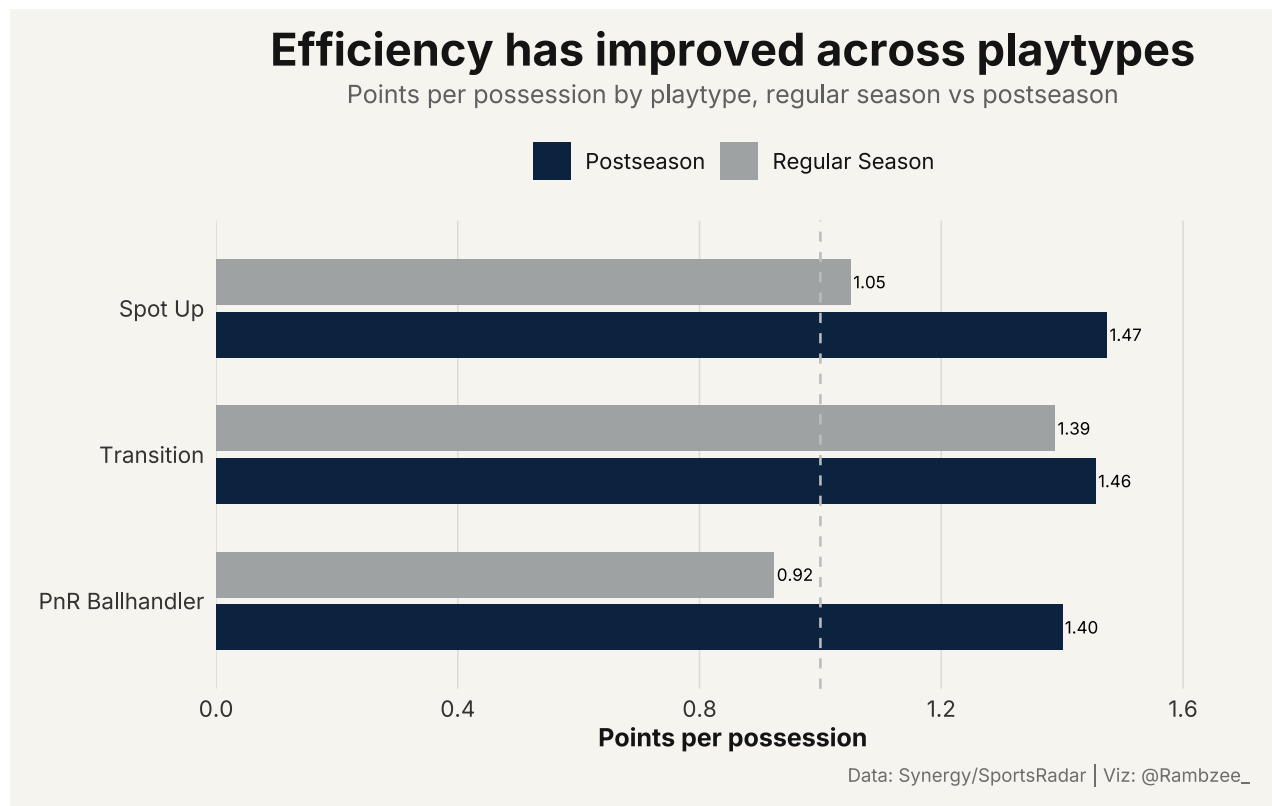
Table 3: Ayo Dosunmu shot profile by zone

Zone	Volume	FG% (League Avg)	rFG%
Restricted Area	313 att	62.3% (66.9%)	-4.6%
Paint (Non-RA)	120 att	42.5% (44.5%)	-2.0%
Midrange	34 att	50.0% (43.3%)	+6.7%
3PT	279 att	43.7% (36.2%)	+7.5%

The shot diet fits what Minnesota needed around Edwards, Gobert, and Randle. Dosunmu can run, attack space, and stretch the floor without drifting into a midrange-heavy diet

That is why the playoff burst does not feel completely random. Some shooting regression is likely, especially from three, but the foundation is strong with consistent rim pressure, enough touch in the paint, strong spot-up value, and added free throw pressure in the postseason. When defenders go under, he can punish them. When they chase, he has enough burst to get downhill.

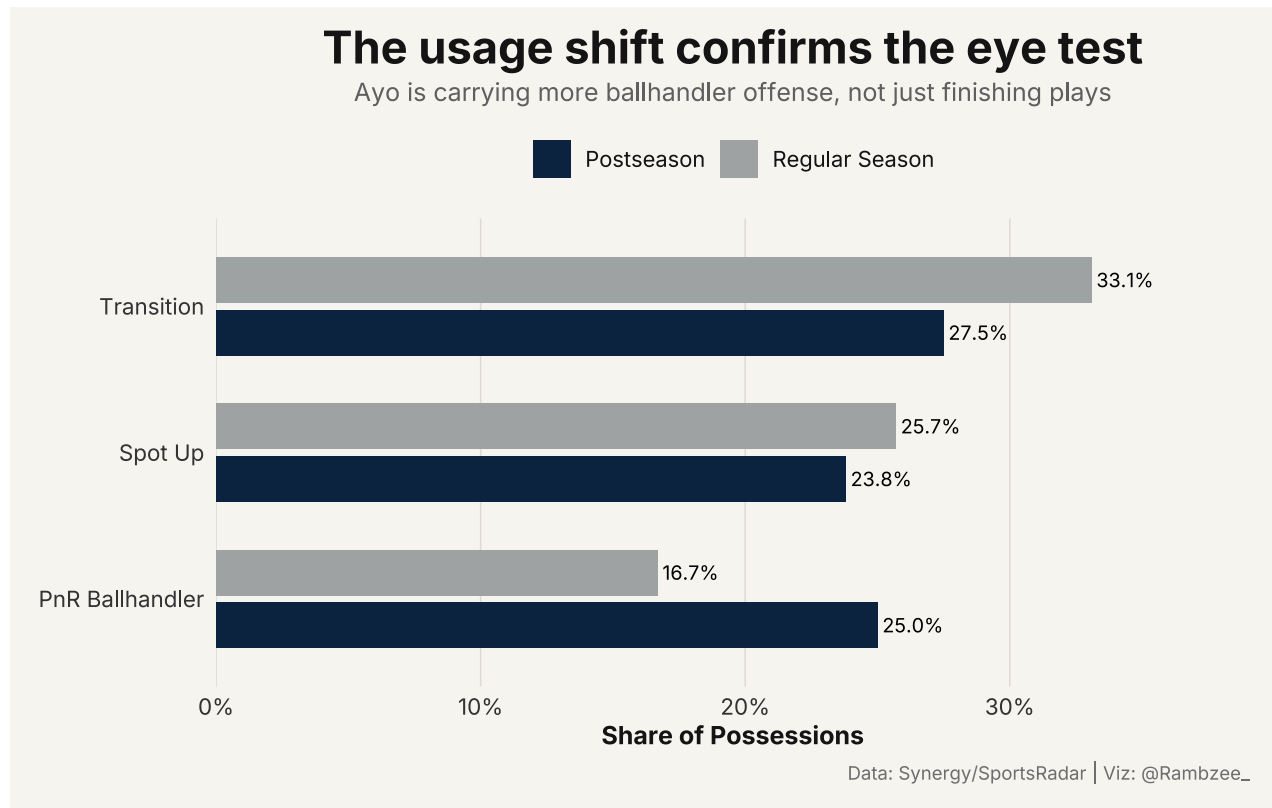
Playtype Translation



Ayo has been even more effective within the same playtypes that defined his scoring all season. The most important one is pick-and-roll.

He's at **1.40 PPP** as a postseason pick-and-roll ballhandler, even if it's only about 20 possessions. That sample isn't enough to treat him like a primary initiator, but it does show that Minnesota can put the ball in his hands, run a simple action, and get a good outcome.

That matters more with Edwards out. The Wolves don't need Dosunmu to become a high-end creator. They need him to handle second-side actions, attack soft coverage, and keep the offense from sputtering out when the initial play breaks down. So far, he's been able to do that without forcing possessions or turning the game into isolation-heavy offense.



The volume shift is just as important as the efficiency. Transition and spot-ups are still a major part of his value, but the postseason role has included more direct creation, especially as a pick-and-roll ballhandler. That was the part people were less sure he had in him. Through this series, he has shown he can handle more responsibility without moving too far away from what already made him effective.

Table 4: Ayo Dosunmu core offensive playtypes with the Timberwolves: regular season vs postseason

Playtype	RS Poss	RS Time%	RS PPP	PO Poss	PO Time%	PO PPP	PPP Δ
Transition	103	33.1%	1.388	22	27.5%	1.455	+0.067
PnR Ballhandler	52	16.7%	0.923	20	25.0%	1.400	+0.477
Spot Up	80	25.7%	1.050	19	23.8%	1.474	+0.424

League Context

The improvement is not just internal. Relative to the rest of the playoff field, Dosunmu has held up well as both a shooter and a pick-and-roll ballhandler.

Table 5: Top playoff pick-and-roll scorers by PPP (Min 4 GP, 4 Poss/G)

Rank	Player	Poss/G	PPP
1	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	8.3	1.58
2	Paul George	4.0	1.40
3	Ayo Dosunmu	4.2	1.29
4	Donovan Mitchell	7.3	1.17
5	Payton Pritchard	6.0	1.11
6	Jalen Williams	4.0	1.00
7	CJ McCollum	12.4	1.00
8	Franz Wagner	4.8	0.97
9	Tyrese Maxey	9.8	0.95
10	Jrue Holiday	6.8	0.94

Table 6: Top playoff three-point shooters by percentage (Min 4 GP, 3+ 3PA/G)

Rank	Player	3PA/G	3P%
1	Julian Champagne	4.2	61.5%
2	Royce O'Neale	3.3	58.8%
3	Ayo Dosunmu	4.4	57.1%
4	OG Anunoby	4.8	54.5%
5	Victor Wembanyama	3.3	52.6%
6	Paul George	5.2	52.4%
7	Rui Hachimura	4.8	50.0%
8	Onyeka Okongwu	4.0	47.8%
9	Quentin Grimes	3.2	47.8%
10	Donte DiVincenzo	5.8	47.8%

The Game 4 Swing

Table 7: 40+ point playoff games off the bench in NBA history

Rank	Player	Points	TS%
1	Fred Brown	45	59.1%
2	Ayo Dosunmu	43	96.5%
3	Steph Curry	40	60.0%
4	Nick Van Exel	40	68.8%

Game 4 was the proof of concept. Edwards and DiVincenzo went down. The Wolves were staring down a team that is more talented, more offensively explosive, powered by one of the best offensive duos ever, and they cut off the faucet defensively while Ayo took over. His heroic 43 point game stamped his name as one of the best bench guards in basketball, and his performance was up there with some other bench greats.

Table 8: Most efficient 40+ point playoff games in NBA history

Rank	Player	Points	TS%	Playoffs
1	Terry Porter	41	101.7%	1992
2	Damian Lillard	55	96.8%	2021
3	Ayo Dosunmu	43	96.5%	2026
4	Dirk Nowitzki	48	93.9%	2011
5	Devin Booker	47	90.8%	2023
6	Anthony Davis	43	90.6%	2020
7	Devin Booker	47	90.5%	2021
8	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	42	90.2%	2026
9	Jason Richardson	42	89.7%	2010
10	Jamal Murray	50	89.4%	2020

Beyond just the bench role, his 40-point explosion also sits among the most efficient we've seen in NBA Playoff History.

Closing

Losing both Edwards and DiVincenzo is a massive hit to Minnesota's deep playoff hopes. Dosunmu was not brought in to carry this kind of offensive burden, but the injuries have pushed him into a role larger than the Wolves likely expected when they traded for him.

So far, he has given them a real answer. Minnesota's game plan has been strong, and the execution has mostly matched it, but Denver is not the kind of team you can treat as finished. If the Wolves are going to close out a former championship core, they need steady contributions across the roster. Dosunmu's efficiency has become one of the more reliable ways they have managed the non-Edwards stretches.

That matters beyond this series too. If Minnesota advances before Edwards returns, Dosunmu will likely keep carrying more creation responsibility than expected. He does not have to save the offense by himself, but he does have to keep giving the Wolves enough downhill pressure, shooting, and decision-making to give their offense a chance.

For a bench guard, this is already one of the better offensive playoff series on record: substantial scoring volume, absurd efficiency, and a 43-point game that sits near the top of multiple historical lists. Dosunmu cannot be held to the ridiculous standard he has set so far, but this stretch has shown why Minnesota targeted him in the first place.

He can fit around stars, but he is not useless without them. For a Wolves team trying to survive long enough for its franchise player to return, that flexibility has become one of the biggest reasons their season is still alive.